

PAKISTAN
Total Number: **450+**

F-16 Fighting Falcon
No. : **85**
US made 4th-generation multi-role fighter; to be upgraded

Mirage III, Mirage 5
No. : **87 & 92**
Mirage III and Mirage 5 are ageing fighters made by France's Dassault Aviation

JF-17 Thunder
No. : **161**
Multirole fighter developed by Pakistan Aeronautical Complex and Chengdu Aerospace Corporation

J-10C
No. : **36**
Chinese-made multirole fighter, equipped with PL-15 missiles

ACQUISITION:
Probable purchase of 40 J-35 from China

IN DEVELOPMENT:
Sixth-generation J-36 and J-50

J-35 A
No. : Over **50**
A newer 5th-generation stealth fighter

J-10 (variants J-10A/B/C/S)
No. : Around **300**
Multirole fighter comparable to the upgraded US-made F16

J-16
No. : Over **350**
4.5-generation multi-role fighter like the Rafale

J-20
No. : Nearly **400**
China's first multi-role 5th-generation stealth fighter; over 1,000 to be in service by 2030



SOME EXPERTS BELIEVE THAT SUCH A BIG INDUCTION OF RAFALES WOULD HAMPER INDIA'S OWN FIGHTER JET PROGRAMME, AS MUCH OF THE IAF'S CAPITAL BUDGET WOULD BE DIVERTED TO IT

capable of full technological mastery without external dependence. "India does not own the intellectual property rights (IPR) for the Rafale platform. Major upgrades require approval and support from the original equipment manufacturer (OEM)," says a military aviation expert. "This continued reliance on the OEM constrains self-reliance in advanced combat aircraft development."

Christopher Clary believes that Rafales, even at these numbers, will be inadequate for the Indian military. "Tejas will provide some capability, but India will need to make progress on the Advanced Medium Combat Aircraft (the fifth-generation AMCA) if it wants to avoid having to spend hard-earned rupees on another large fighter aircraft acquisition in the medium-term," he says.

Of the IAF's 29 fighter squadrons (each has 18-20 aircraft), 13 comprise Su-30MKIs, three each have MiG-29UPGs and Mirage-2000s, besides six squadrons of SEPECAT Jaguars, and two each of LCA Tejas Mk1 and Rafales. From 2030 onwards, the MiG-29, Jaguar and Mirage-2000 units will start being decommissioned, with all phased out by 2035. To maintain combat strength, the Su-30MKI fleet needs upgrades and Air Headquarters is considering acquiring some fifth-generation Russian Su-57 'Felon' squadrons as an interim measure till the AMCA joins the fleet from 2035.

AIR ADVERSARIES

Meanwhile, Pakistan and China are forging ahead with their air force modernisation. The US has recently cleared a $686-million upgrade package for Pakistani F-16 jets, which will extend their life till 2040. Pakistan operates J-10C fighters armed with PL-15 long-range beyond-visual-range (LR-BVR) missiles and has sought to acquire the Chinese J-35A fifth-gen stealth aircraft. China has nearly 400 J-20 fifth-gen fighters and is expected to field about 1,000 J-20s by 2030. Combined with the induction of the J-35A and modernised J-10s and J-16s, China's total fighter strength could exceed 2,200 modern platforms.

"The advances in Chinese hardware mean that India's qualitative advantage over Pakistan (which buys Chinese aircraft) is arguably closing, while China gains an overall quantitative superiority over the IAF," says Clary.

The IAF is seeking to reduce the Russian basket too. Key IAF officials say that Russian platforms (the Sukhoi Su 30 MKI forms the backbone of the fighter fleet) are cheaper, but their life-cycle costs surpass Western aircraft over time. India is balancing defence purchases across Russia, the US and Europe, while accelerating the development of its own platforms. The Rafale deal should be seen in this context too.

Ultimately though, this deal is not a contradiction to India's push for indigenous jets but a calculated bridge to it. By inducting a proven, combat-ready jet to address urgent operational gaps, India has bought itself time—to design, test and produce its own fighters. ■